

HOW COMMUNITIES CAN STOP DESTRUCTIVE DEVELOPMENT PROJECTS IN LIBYA

INTRODUCTION & FRAMEWORK

Concern for the environment in Libya turns above all on water drawn from the deep past — for this is a vast desert nation on the Mediterranean, divided since its revolution between rival governments, whose defining environmental reality is its dependence on fossil water: the **Great Man-Made River**, the largest such project on earth, which mines ancient, non-renewable groundwater from beneath the Sahara and pipes it hundreds of kilometres to the coastal cities, supplying more than nine-tenths of the country's water from a reserve that will not refill. Libya is one of the driest nations on earth and yet the holder of one of the largest freshwater treasures ever found beneath the Sahara — a fractured state with real technical institutions but no unified government, where the deadly failure of the neglected dams at **Derna** showed in a single night what neglect and division can cost. The oil is both the economy and the prize of the division, and the desert presses on a water-scarce land. There is no swift or landmark victory to promise, and parts of the country are dangerous. But Libya's is a crisis of management as much as scarcity, and that gives real ground.

In a divided and often insecure nation, those who would defend Libya's water and land work through what still functions, from outside, and only where it is safe — and the tools are real. The distinctive lever is the **finite-water argument**: the fossil aquifer beneath the desert is non-renewable and depleting, so a project that mines, wastes, or gambles it is self-defeating in one of the driest nations on earth — and, because the aquifer is shared, the **transboundary water frameworks** with Libya's neighbours are a real channel. The deadly failure at Derna demands **accountability and documentation** for the neglect of ageing infrastructure — a concrete standard no future project or dam can be allowed to ignore. The oil's harms can be confronted through the **pollution and revenue-transparency frameworks**. The **technical institutions that still function** — the water and infrastructure bodies — remain real avenues where it is safe. And the **international and UN frameworks and bodies**, which a divided state still engages, carry safeguards, accountability, and support. But these tools have grave limits, and this guide states them plainly. The country is divided between rival governments, and parts of it are insecure and dangerous, so the work must run through what functions and from outside, protecting everyone. The fossil aquifer is finite and depleting — a problem no amount of pumping can solve, only careful use can slow. The infrastructure is ageing and neglected, as Derna proved in a single deadly night. The oil is entangled in the division and the conflict. And no swift or landmark victory is to be promised. So the work must centre on what is safe and functioning — the water and infrastructure institutions that still work, the international and UN bodies, the communities where it is safe — never exposing or endangering anyone. And the honest prize is the finite water safeguarded and its mining scrutinised, the infrastructure held to account as Derna demands, the oil's harms confronted, on the safe and functioning ground — not a swift stop in a fractured state. Above all, protect the people.

The Whole Strategy in One Idea

You cannot rely on a unified state, because Libya has none, and you must never endanger anyone in an insecure land. What can be done is to work through what still functions and from outside: press the finite-water argument that mining a non-renewable aquifer is self-defeating, invoke the transboundary frameworks, demand the accountability the Derna disaster made undeniable, confront the oil's harms through the transparency frameworks, and rely on the technical institutions that still work and the

international and UN bodies — all only where it is safe, and protecting everyone.

Be Honest About Which Fight You're In

Libya is among the hardest settings in this guide, and honesty about that is the first and gravest discipline. The state is fractured between rival governments, parts of the country are dangerous, the fossil aquifer is finite and cannot be refilled, the infrastructure is neglected as Derna showed, and the oil is entangled in the conflict. This is not a fight for a swift or landmark victory. It is careful work through what still functions and from outside, whose realistic prize is the finite water safeguarded, the infrastructure held to account, and the oil's harms confronted — pursued only where safe, and protecting everyone.

HOW THE SYSTEM WORKS

Who Actually Decides

Power in a fractured state is divided and contested between rival governments, but the decisions a careful effort can reach run through what still functions: the **technical water and infrastructure institutions** that operate the Great Man-Made River and the dams; the **oil institutions** and the transparency frameworks around them; the **international and UN bodies** engaged with a divided Libya; and the **communities** where it is safe. Avoid the insecure areas and the armed factions, and map who genuinely functions before spending a week on it.

How a Project Moves — and Where You Jump In

A harm — a scheme that over-mines the fossil water, a neglected dam, an oil pollution — advances through the divided state and its institutions, but the entry points are real: the finite-water argument and the transboundary frameworks for a water scheme; the Derna accountability standard for the infrastructure; the pollution and transparency frameworks for the oil. Enter through the technical institutions that still function and the international and UN bodies, only where it is safe.

Follow the Money and the Permissions

Follow the water: what a scheme mines from a finite, non-renewable aquifer that will not refill. Follow the infrastructure: which dams and pipelines are neglected, as Derna's were. Follow the oil: its pollution, and the transparency of its revenues amid the division. Follow the international engagement: which UN and international bodies hold safeguards and accountability. The leverage lies in the finite-water argument, the transboundary and accountability frameworks, and the transparency mechanisms.

Who's Supposed to Be Watching

Domestic oversight is fractured, but the technical water and infrastructure institutions that still function, the oil-transparency frameworks, and — crucially — the international and UN bodies engaged with Libya are the watchers a careful case engages. Derna showed the cost of neglected oversight; the accountability it demands is now a standard to hold the infrastructure to.

QUICK REFERENCE: SUCCESS RATES

No Libyan effort easily halts a harm in a fractured, insecure state, and honesty requires saying so. What the tools can deliver is the finite water safeguarded and its mining scrutinised, the infrastructure held to account, the oil's harms confronted. The single most decisive move is **the finite-water argument backed by the**

international, UN, and functioning-institution channels, because mining a non-renewable aquifer is self-defeating in one of the driest nations on earth, and because the international and UN bodies can act where a divided state cannot. The finite-water argument is the distinctive lever; the Derna accountability standard the sharpest handle on infrastructure; the transparency frameworks the oil's; and the international and UN channels the reach. Nothing here is swift or safe by default — and everything must protect the people.

STEP 1: TARGET IDENTIFICATION

Ask five questions. **What is the harm?** — the over-mining of the finite water, the neglected dam or infrastructure, the oil pollution. **How is it self-defeating or negligent?** — how it squanders a non-renewable aquifer, or repeats Derna's neglect. **Which framework reaches it?** — the transboundary water, the Derna accountability, the pollution or transparency. **Which channel functions and is safe?** — the technical institution, the international or UN body, the safe community. **How is everyone kept safe?** — the overriding question. Pick the harm where a functioning, safe channel and a real framework give the clearest handle.

STEP 2: DOCUMENTATION — HOW TO BUILD AN UNASSAILABLE CASE

Build the case in layers, safely. **Layer one: the harm** — the finite water over-mined, the infrastructure neglected, the oil pollution, documented where it is safe and by international data where it is not. **Layer two: the framework and the standard** — the finite-water and transboundary argument, the Derna accountability standard, the pollution and transparency frameworks. **Layer three: the channel and the safety** — which functioning institution, international, or UN body to reach, and the absolute discipline of avoiding the insecure areas and protecting everyone. A case built on the finite-water argument and the accountability Derna demands, carried through the functioning and international channels, is the one that can move a fractured state, safely.

WHAT TO GATHER, AND WHERE TO FIND IT

Gather the **harm record**: the finite aquifer's depletion, the neglected infrastructure, the oil pollution, documented safely and by international data. Gather the **framework record**: the transboundary water agreements, the Derna accountability standard, the pollution and transparency frameworks. Gather the **channel record**: the functioning technical institutions, the international and UN bodies. Gather the **safety discipline**: confirm the work avoids the insecure areas, runs through what functions, and exposes no one.

STEP 3: BUILDING THE FUNCTIONING-INSTITUTION AND INTERNATIONAL COALITION

The coalition here works through what functions, from outside, and safely. Build it from the **technical experts and institutions** in water, infrastructure, and oil that still function; the **international and UN bodies** engaged with Libya; the **communities** where it is safe; and the **diaspora and international partners** who can carry the case from outside. Frame everything around the water, the infrastructure, and the oil's harms, never around the political division; avoid the armed factions and insecure areas; and protect everyone involved absolutely.

STEP 4: THE FINITE-WATER ARGUMENT, THE DERNA STANDARD & THE FRAMEWORKS — CONTESTING THE HARM SAFELY

Set expectations honestly: the levers are real but constrained by division and insecurity, so the prize is the water safeguarded, the infrastructure held to account, the oil confronted — not a swift stop.

The Finite-Water Argument and the Transboundary Frameworks

The distinctive lever is the **finite-water argument**: the fossil aquifer is non-renewable and depleting, so mining, wasting, or gambling it is self-defeating in one of the driest nations on earth. And because the aquifer is shared, the **transboundary water frameworks** with Libya's neighbours are a real channel. Press the harm as the squandering of a finite treasure.

The Derna Accountability Standard

The deadly failure at Derna demands **accountability and documentation** for the neglect of ageing infrastructure — a concrete standard, written in a single night's tragedy, that no future dam or project can be allowed to ignore. Hold the infrastructure to the lesson Derna paid for.

The Oil Frameworks and the International Channels

The oil's harms can be confronted through the **pollution and revenue-transparency frameworks**, and the **international and UN bodies** carry safeguards, accountability, and support a divided state cannot. Pursued together — the finite-water argument and transboundary frameworks, the Derna standard, and the oil and international channels — these levers safeguard the water and hold the harm to account, while protecting everyone.

TURNING YOUR EVIDENCE INTO ARGUMENTS

Tailor the case to each audience. **For the water institutions**: here is a scheme squandering a finite, non-renewable aquifer that will not refill. **For the transboundary partners**: here is a shared water treasure to protect. **For the infrastructure bodies**: here is the neglect Derna warned against, and the accountability it demands. **For the oil-transparency frameworks**: here is pollution and revenue to bring to light. **For the international and UN bodies**: here is a harm a divided state cannot address, and the support it needs. **The golden rule**: ground everything in the finite-water argument and the Derna accountability standard, carry it through the functioning and international channels, and protect everyone.

STEP 5: MEDIA STRATEGY

Media must be handled with the greatest care in a divided, insecure state, and largely from outside. Frame any attention around **the finite water and the Derna lesson**: a non-renewable treasure being squandered, and the neglected infrastructure that killed thousands — never around the political division. Carry it through the international and UN outlets and the diaspora, never through anything that exposes anyone inside or touches the armed factions. A few cautions govern everything: never expose anyone; avoid the political division; frame it around the water, the infrastructure, and the oil; and let the finite-water science and the Derna accountability carry the weight.

EMAILS & LETTERS

Keep every message safe, framed on water and infrastructure, and protective of everyone.

8A — To a functioning water institution: set out how the scheme squanders a finite, non-renewable aquifer.

8B — On the transboundary aquifer: invoke the shared-water frameworks with Libya's neighbours.

8C — On the infrastructure: document the neglect and demand the accountability Derna made undeniable.

8D — On the oil: flag the pollution and invoke the revenue-transparency frameworks.

8E — To an international or UN body: describe the harm a divided state cannot address and request engagement.

8F — To a technical expert or institution: request the water, infrastructure, or pollution data.

8G — To the diaspora or an international partner: share the case and ask for advocacy from outside.

8H — To the international public: summarise the finite water and the Derna lesson, and ask for attention — without exposing anyone.

IF YOU HAVE LITTLE TIME OR FEW RESOURCES: THE RAPID-FIRE VERSION

The first 48 hours: document the harm — the finite water squandered, the infrastructure neglected — safely and by international data; write the one-page finite-water-and-Derna case; identify the safe, functioning channel. **The fastest-moving levers:** the finite-water argument, the Derna accountability standard, and the international and UN bodies. **Emergency action:** for a dangerous, neglected dam or infrastructure, the Derna standard and the international bodies are the sharpest handles — raise them safely. Throughout, avoid the insecure areas and expose no one.

WHEN THE SYSTEM IS TILTED

The field here is not merely tilted but fractured and dangerous: no unified state, rival governments, insecure regions, and a finite aquifer. Recognise it plainly and adjust the aim — not a swift stop, but the water safeguarded, the infrastructure held to account, the oil confronted. Lean on the levers the fracture cannot reach: the finite-water argument, the transboundary and Derna-accountability frameworks, the international and UN bodies. And accept the honest limits — the division, the insecurity, the depleting aquifer — while still defending the water through what functions, and protecting everyone.

WHEN IT'S ACTUAL CORRUPTION — AND WHO BENEFITS

In a divided state, the dangers include the armed factions, the contested oil wealth, and the negligence that drowned Derna. Respond only through the **functioning and international channels:** the finite-water argument, the transboundary and accountability frameworks, the oil-transparency mechanisms, the international and UN bodies, the documented record. Never through anything touching the armed factions or the political division. **On safety and protection:** this governs everything. Libya is fractured between rival governments and parts of it are dangerous. Work through the functioning-institution, international, UN, and community channels, only where it is safe; never expose or endanger anyone; avoid the insecure areas and

armed factions entirely; frame the work around the water, the infrastructure, and the oil; and treat the safety of all as the first consideration. Protection is the governing rule.

INTEGRATION & TIMELINE: RUNNING ALL FIVE STEPS TOGETHER

The steps run in parallel, through what functions and only where safe. The documented harm feeds the finite-water argument, the Derna accountability, and the oil-transparency case at once; the functioning-institution, international, and community coalition organises safely alongside; any attention runs largely from outside. A rough timeline: **weeks one to four**, document the harm and identify the framework and the safe channel; **months two to six**, press the finite-water argument, the transboundary and Derna frameworks, and the international and UN bodies; **beyond**, sustain the water's defence and the accountability. The core discipline: through what functions, from outside where needed, and protective of everyone.

FINAL ASSESSMENT

Libya is among the hardest and most fractured grounds in this guide, and this guide does not pretend otherwise. It does not claim a harm can be swiftly stopped in a divided, insecure state, or that the finite aquifer can be refilled, or that a landmark victory exists — none of that is true, and parts of the country are dangerous. What it claims is narrower and real: that in one of the driest nations on earth, mining a non-renewable fossil aquifer is self-defeating, and the transboundary frameworks give a channel; that the deadly failure at Derna wrote an accountability standard the infrastructure can be held to; that the oil's harms can be confronted through the pollution and transparency frameworks; that the technical institutions that still function are real avenues where it is safe; and that the international and UN bodies carry safeguards a divided state cannot. The levers work through what functions and from outside, and the prize is the finite water safeguarded, the infrastructure held to account, the oil's harms confronted — not a swift stop. For a fractured, water-scarce desert nation, that careful work — through what functions, only where safe, and protecting everyone — is not a lesser ambition. It is the only responsible and effective one.